

Australia Daily Brief

Friday, September 11, 2026

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RE: Peters dismisses Treasury over 2027 Forum bid · NZ First offers Pacific overstayers two-year amnesty · Ex-envoy says Coalition was 'delighted' by Beijing coercion · ADF drone shield has China links · Rudd enters Austal USA fight

ASX 200

8,741

-2.94%

AUD/USD

0.7176

-0.42%

NZX 50

13,580

-2.82%

NZD/USD

0.5818

-1.10%

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• TODAY AT A GLANCE

- 1 Winston Peters rejected Treasury's finding that his offer to host the 2027 Pacific Islands Forum bypassed Cabinet, telling RNZ Pacific that Treasury "can write what it likes" and that hosting rotates automatically among members.
- 2 New Zealand First built a twenty-four month amnesty for Pacific visa overstayers into an otherwise restrictive immigration platform, released 57 days before the November 7 election.
- 3 Graham Fletcher, ambassador in Beijing from 2019 to 2023, said some Coalition MPs seemed "almost delighted" to be targeted by Chinese coercion and "paraded" the list of 14 grievances handed over by Chinese diplomats.

• TOP STORIES

NZ-FOREIGN-POLICY

Peters brushes off Treasury on 2027 Forum hosting: 'Treasury can write what it likes'

Winston Peters said he had no obligation to take his offer to host the 2027 Pacific Islands Forum leaders meeting to Cabinet, telling RNZ Pacific he gave Prime Minister **Christopher Luxon** a mid-year heads-up and that "you don't know whether or not [PIF] are going to be taking up your offer." Treasury advised Finance Minister **Nicola Willis** in March to gut his *NZ\$30 million* funding proposal, saying the value for money of the bid was not clear and that the absence of Cabinet approval made strategic alignment harder to assess. Peters said hosting rotates among members and it was New Zealand's turn: "Every Cabinet minister should understand that, even if they weren't told."

per RNZ Pacific: "'Treasury can write what it likes': Winston Peters defends Pacific Islands Forum hosting decision"

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Former ambassador says Coalition MPs seemed 'almost delighted' by Beijing's coercion

Graham Fletcher, Australia's ambassador to China from 2019 to 2023, criticised the former Morrison government's handling of Beijing's coercion campaign, saying some in the Coalition "almost delighted" in being targeted and "paraded" the list of 14 grievances handed over by Chinese diplomats. Speaking on a podcast hosted by an Australian National University academic, he called China under **Xi Jinping** increasingly "smug" and closed to new ideas, and warned ideological fixations risk sapping the country's entrepreneurial drive. His posting spanned both the collapse of bilateral ties in 2020-21 and their stabilisation after Labor's 2022 election win.

per ABC News: "Former China ambassador warns Beijing is becoming 'smug' and closed"

AU-DEFENSE

Counter-drone system fielded by the ADF carries China links, The Australian reports

A drone defence capability deployed by the Australian Defence Force has links to China, The Australian reported under the headline "flying blind" on RAAF drone defence. The paper did not disclose the supplier, the contract value, or the units involved in the portion of the story published outside its paywall. The report lands in the same week universities pushed back against new national security rules governing defence-linked research.

per The Australian: "ADF deploys drone shield with alarming China links"

• OVERNIGHT

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY [Putin lands in Delhi before an 11-member BRICS summit; Xi arrives Saturday](#) · ABC News

Vladimir Putin arrived in India for talks ahead of the two-day BRICS summit opening on Saturday, with the leaders of China, Iran, Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates expected. It will be **Xi Jinping's** first visit to India since 2019, six years after a deadly military clash on the disputed Himalayan border. Flights, visas and high-level contacts between the two have gradually been restored, though a widening trade deficit and the contested frontier remain.

AU-DEFENSE [Rudd enters the takeover fight over Austal's US shipbuilding arm](#) · The Australian

Kevin Rudd intervened in the contest for Austal's United States business, arguing the navy builder's US arm must remain in Australian hands, The Australian reported. A second bid for Austal USA, valued above \$1.73 billion, landed earlier this month. The company builds for the US Navy from Alabama and is a supplier to the Royal Australian Navy.

AU-POLITICS [NSW Aboriginal Land Council quits Closing the Gap as land rights row deepens](#) · The Australian

The NSW Aboriginal Land Council withdrew from the Closing the Gap agreement, The Australian reported, as a dispute over land rights escalates. The peak body's exit removes a signatory from the national partnership framework that binds Commonwealth, state and territory governments to Indigenous bodies on agreed targets.

AU-POLITICS [AFP will not reveal disciplinary outcomes over 'unlawful' arrest of First Nations teenager](#) · ABC News

An internal Australian Federal Police investigation into the mistaken arrest of a First Nations teenager found no evidence of discrimination or use of excessive force. The AFP declined to say what, if any, disciplinary action followed, leaving the outcome of the internal process undisclosed.

TRADE-ECONOMY

[Nepal puts flood reconstruction at \\$6.67 billion and calls it a shared responsibility](#) · ABC News

Nepal's foreign ministry said recovery from the August 26 floods will cost *\$US4.78 billion*, or \$6.67 billion, of which \$US57.67 million is needed for short-term reconstruction over the next six months. Spokesman **Lok Bahadur Chhetri** said a post-disaster needs assessment is under way to determine the full extent of loss and damage. Prime Minister **Balendra Shah** is expected to raise wealthier countries' contribution at the UN General Assembly later this month.

• STAT OF THE DAY

NZ\$30m

Peters' bid to fund New Zealand's 2027 Forum hosting

Treasury advised cutting the proposal, recommending about \$10 million in line with the cost of hosting in 2011, and noted \$6.4 million of it was for policy work.

RNZ Pacific

• PACIFIC WIRE

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · PNG POST-COURIER

[Marape returns to Port Moresby after driving the new Transnational Highway](#)

Prime Minister **James Marape** arrived back in Port Moresby after his maiden drive along the new highway, reporting on the leg to Kikori and saying the trip "opened everyone's eyes to the other side of life." The pilot track spans *1,300 kilometres* between Port Moresby and Lae, a drive of more than 18 hours, and Marape travelled in a ministerial convoy.

COOK ISLANDS · RNZ PACIFIC

[Headstones toppled at Rarotonga cemetery holding Cook Islands First World War graves](#)

Headstones were knocked over at Nikao Cemetery in Rarotonga, the largest burial site for Cook Islands soldiers who served in the First World War. The Cook Islands Investment Corporation notified Australian-based researcher **Cate Walker**, who has led the cemetery's restoration for more than a decade and whose mother's headstone was among those damaged. Walker called for those responsible to be prosecuted and said cemetery vandalism there had never happened before.

REGIONAL · ISLANDS BUSINESS

[University of the South Pacific installs its 33rd Chancellor](#)

The University of the South Pacific marked the formal installation of its 33rd Chancellor alongside a graduation ceremony for students from across the Blue Pacific, Islands Business reported. The published account does not name the incoming chancellor. USP is the region's principal multi-country tertiary institution, jointly owned by its member governments.

• NEW ZEALAND

NZ-POLITICS · RNZ PACIFIC

NZ First offers Pacific overstayers a two-year amnesty inside a tougher immigration package

New Zealand First will give Pacific visa overstayers *24 months* to apply to remain legally, an allowance extended to no other nationality in recognition of what the party called its "unique and close bond" with the Pacific; those who fail to regularise would be deported and permanently ineligible for future visas. The wider package, unveiled by **Winston Peters** at Auckland's Immigration Conference, proposes a referendum on a 20,000 resident visa cap, stricter birthright citizenship rules, broader deportation liability, and a resident cap tied to funded infrastructure. Peters said immigration "is a privilege, not a right," and the party is demanding one of its MPs hold the immigration portfolio in the next government.

• CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

Marrickville Golf Club was the only golf club among 220 funded projects

Anthony Albanese's \$6 million election promise to the Marrickville Golf Club was the sole golf club on a list of 220 projects given public money, the ABC reported, at a club he lived near, frequented, and where he launched Labor candidates. He holds an honorary membership given 15 years ago and not declared, exempting him from the club's \$1,100 annual fee.

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

Hanson holds the line on Hastie cartoon as he calls her 'weak and glass-jawed'

Pauline Hanson refused to withdraw a Please Explain animation that depicts Liberal frontbencher **Andrew Hastie**, a former SAS officer, as a "traitor." Hastie escalated from calling Hanson and One Nation treasury spokesman **Barnaby Joyce** "lying cowards" on Wednesday to "weak and glass-jawed" on Thursday. One Nation is simultaneously standing by **Warren Pickering**, its leader for the November Victorian election, after his admissions of extensive past drug use.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

South Australian Liberals move party money into a trust against federal intervention

The South Australian Liberals created a legal trust to shield millions of dollars from any federal takeover of the division, The Australian reported. The manoeuvre follows persistent speculation about intervention in the state branch and hands the federal organisation a smaller financial lever if it moves.

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

One Nation MP to move for a one-year pause on Murray-Darling water buybacks

Farrer One Nation MP **David Farley** will put a motion to federal parliament next week calling for a one-year pause on water buybacks in the Murray-Darling Basin, saying the current basin plan is too skewed towards environmental interests. He cited the Murray-Darling Basin Authority's admission that a chapter on farming's role was omitted from a "What We Heard" report.

• BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · ABC NEWS

Former Australian trade negotiator maps the fallout from Trump's tariff strategy

Dmitry Grozoubinski, a former Australian trade negotiator and author of *Why Politicians Lie About Trade*, told Alan Kohler that tariffs are being used as political weapons in a break with decades of economic orthodoxy. The discussion covered **Mark Carney's** retaliation from Canada and what the upheaval means for Australia, with trade routes now central to the Iran war and the Strait of Hormuz at its heart.

AFR

Hanson reopens the question of how much superannuation is too much

The Australian Financial Review asked how much superannuation is too much and whether the 12 percent contribution rate strikes the right trade-off between living standards today and in retirement, after **Pauline Hanson** raised the issue. The rate has been broadly settled policy across both major parties.

TRADE-ECONOMY · THE AUSTRALIAN

The Australian questions the economic return on education exports

Australia's education "industry" is not the bonanza it is sold as, The Australian's economics section argued. The claim cuts against the standard framing of international students as one of the country's largest export earners, a framing that underpins current migration and university funding debates.

TRADE-ECONOMY · THE AUSTRALIAN

Volkswagen and Mercedes cut thousands of jobs as Chinese brands take European share

Volkswagen and Mercedes are shedding thousands of jobs as Chinese carmakers gain ground in Europe, The Australian reported. The same brands compete directly in the Australian market, where Chinese electric vehicle imports have grown rapidly.

• UPCOMING

SEP
2026

UN General Assembly high-level week, where Nepal will press wealthier states on flood reconstruction costs

Loss-and-damage claims from climate-exposed states set the terms Pacific members will use on the same platform.

OCT
26

Advance voting opens in the New Zealand general election

NZ First's Pacific overstayer amnesty and resident visa cap go before voters from this date.

NOV
7

New Zealand general election

Decides whether Peters keeps the foreign affairs portfolio as Wellington prepares to host the 2027 Forum.

NOV
2026

Victorian state election, with One Nation led by Warren Pickering

Tests One Nation's strength against the Liberals in a state contest running alongside the Hanson-Hastie fight.

SEP
2027

Pacific Islands Forum Leaders Meeting hosted by New Zealand

Treasury has flagged unavoidable costs and scope to cut them, so the final hosting budget is still unsettled.

• THE WIRE

AU-POLITICS · SYDNEY MORNING HERALD

Coalition bets voters mistrust Albanese more than big tech on online reform

The Sydney Morning Herald argued the Coalition's attack on Labor's online reform package assumes voters trust the platforms more than the prime minister, and that the debate mixes genuine free-speech issues with red herrings.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

Grace Tame apologises for calling October 7 rapes 'propaganda'

Former Australian of the Year **Grace Tame** apologised for describing accounts of rapes during the October 7 attacks as propaganda, The Australian reported.

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

Victoria Police investigate pork products thrown at Warragul Mosque

Security footage shows a man throwing bacon and ham near the entrance of the Warragul Mosque in regional Victoria on Wednesday, days after a social media influencer posted a video of the building. The mosque, which opened last year, called the act an attempt to "offend, intimidate, and divide."

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

Kostakidis settles racial discrimination case brought by Jewish group

Former SBS presenter **Mary Kostakidis** and a Jewish group settled their racial discrimination case, The Australian reported, ending a proceeding that had run alongside Australia's broader dispute over speech and antisemitism.

CSIS Australia Chair

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